

new content or asking them to come and play again. Prior to iOS 7, when you were shown a push notification, you had to wait for the download to happen. With remote notifications, it is possible to silently push a notification without prompting the user first. Thus, when a remote notification is initiated, it wakes up your app, downloads the new content and then initiates a local notification to the user about the new content. When the user launches the app after receiving the notification, the content is already downloaded for the user, and no waiting is required!

Thus, by using a combination of the new multi-tasking APIs of iOS 7, you (developers) can significantly improve a user's experience.

Sprite Kit

One of the most interesting development in iOS 7 for game developers is addition of the Sprite Kit. Sprite Kit comes with its own rendering engine, action system, animation system, physics etc for 2D and 2.5 D games. Sprite Kit also comes with an inbuilt particle system that is used in games for generating particle effects. With Sprite Kit the rendering and animation happens inside a SKView. All your game objects are SKNodes and they each have a respective Shape Nodes for physics shape and Emitter Nodes for particle effects.

For particle effects, you get the inbuilt WYSIWYG Editor inside your Xcode so that you can quickly make particle effects without having to use any external tools. The action system of the sprite kit is based on a similar idea as of one of the most popular open source game-engines Cocos2D. You can run actions on your sprites using SKAction Class. The other cool thing about Sprite Kit is that it allows you to handle videos as sprites. Sprite Kit also provides advanced node Searches that help you write complex queries on nodes.

One of the major drawbacks of using Sprite Kit is the inability to write custom shaders, which your app or game might need. Also, using Sprite Kit saves you a lot of time on iOS, but porting your app to Android later will be a painful experience. Also, when it comes to predicted physics, Sprite Kit is not the ideal choice.

Sprite Kit is good for developers who are just starting out and are building fairly simple apps that don't need custom shaders, and you're developing exclusively for iOS. We'd recommend Unity or Cocos2d-X as better choices for cross-platform coding. If you're looking to only code for iOS, but need custom shaders for your app/game, try Cocos2D.

Game Controller

Game Controller Framework is a framework added to iOS 7 that allows you